

University of California, Santa Barbara

**Building Without a Paycheck:
Studying Selection and Proximity Effects at Playa House, UCSB's Founder Residency, Through Personnel Economics**

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Introduction and Executive Summary

Playa House is a residency program at the University of California, Santa Barbara, designed for approximately ten motivated students to live together for a full academic year. They focus on developing their individual projects, with many of them being early-stage startups. Created by a Bay Area native, Leon Khoshnevis, who has managed it for around a year and a half, the initiative is located in Isla Vista and is based on a core concept shared with accelerators like Y Combinator and earlier “hacker houses”: bringing together extremely driven individuals in close quarters, providing access to mentors, investors, and resources, leading to extraordinary results. The first group of participants has just wrapped up their first year. We interviewed Leon over the phone and asked him a series of questions that gave us some insight on the inner workings of Playa House and its admissions process for this project.

Two key characteristics define this program, with the first being its stringent selection process. For the 2025-26 cycle, Playa House took in five students out of about 200 applicants, while the previous cycle accepted seven from nearly one hundred applicants. The second aspect is that, despite this rigorous selection, there is no financial compensation: no salary, no stipend, and no equity claimed in return. Nevertheless, Leon mentions that the first cohort, which included initiatives ranging from autonomous drones to consumer AI to legal workflow automation, collectively achieved six figures in revenue and secured seven figures in funding, including a \$250,000 pre-seed investment. They also won first place in UCSB's New Venture Competition and gained admission into Y Combinator, a prestigious American startup accelerator and venture capital firm. Essentially, Playa House operates like a company that hires only its best candidates and rewards them entirely with non-monetary benefits.

This paper explores personnel economics by examining this research question: “At Playa House, how much of the success of founders can be attributed to the selection of exceptionally talented candidates compared to the benefits of being in a tight-knit, unpaid peer network, and what motivates founders to put in effort without financial rewards?” This exploration is important because the program is poised for expansion, planning to lease additional houses and replicate its model in new areas such as hardware and research. If outcomes are primarily due to careful selection, future growth would need to find more outstanding candidates; however, if the close-knit environment is the crucial factor, maintaining that intimacy in larger or more distributed residences could be challenging. Leon has identified this paradox, noting that the real value of the program lies in “the community,” while also recognizing that a successful resident “would have likely prospered anyway.” Sorting out the impact of selection versus proximity is the main focus of this paper.

To conduct this analysis, our paper outlines a data and empirical framework rather than presenting a finalized study. The proposed data collection would rely on the program's internal documentation of accepted founders and their results, informal records of rejected candidates by the program manager, and a survey designed to assess each resident's status at the time of admission and the extent of their daily peer interactions. The empirical approach will then involve comparing accepted founders with rejected candidates that are the most similar, particularly the borderline cases where the program manager was uncertain. This is in order to differentiate the effects of selection and isolate the residency's direct impact while using variations in interaction levels to investigate whether proximity serves as the driving force.

In summary, this project intends to demonstrate how core concepts of personnel economics like selection and peer proximity are emphasized and influence success in an unpaid work environment.

Founder Roles, Daily Operations, and Organizational Context

At the heart of Playa House is a unique admissions decision primarily made by one individual, the program manager – Leon Khoshnevis. He does not evaluate applicants based on qualifications or initial success like an employer or later investor would, as most candidates lack those credentials. Instead, he seeks a specific attitude: an unconventional passion for a certain issue or sector, along with proof that the individual is already engaged in addressing it. A strong applicant, as he describes, is someone with a unique long-term perspective on the future of their field and envisions themselves working on it for years, rather than simply pursuing a credential or seeking quick results. Personal traits are as important as experience, as two candidates with the same technical skills might be distinguished by the drive that comes through in their discussion. This is the foundation upon which the entire residency is established.

The method of forming that judgment is intentionally unstructured. Instead of giving scores, the program manager conducts a systematic inquiry, urging the applicant to clarify from the basics their motivation for building what they are creating until it becomes evident if they meet his standards. He sees the result as a mixture of two elements: a logical validation that the candidate's reasoning is sound, paired with a significant dose of intuition. Since applicants rarely come with quantifiable results, this approach closely mimics how early-stage investors assess founders long before they have any measurable success, relying on belief rather than a standardized scoring system applicable across all candidates.

That same discretion aids in shaping the program's applicant pool. To understand how the residency is established, we talked to Leon Khoshnevis, the program manager, as the person who identifies candidates, makes each admissions choice, and keeps an informal record of the eventual paths taken by both residents and those who were not accepted. He shared that the first members were sourced from his own connections and previous startup experiences, after which he broadened his search to engineering organizations, classes, and hackathon groups, directly engaging with both organizers and participants. He observed that the most valuable candidates tended to come through first- and second-degree connections rather than through open applications.

Beyond the process of admissions, the program places very few restrictions. There's no established curriculum or specific milestones to achieve; entrepreneurs collaborate continuously and create their own objectives, assessed according to the standards of their own industry instead of a common benchmark. The financial aspects are also quite flexible: the organization does not have a consistent source of income but instead obtains grants when individual founders require assistance and finds sponsors for particular events that need funding. Altogether, these decisions mean that Playa House functions with hardly any of the formal management systems that a typical organization would employ to oversee and assess its employees. What remains is the judgment of the program manager and the atmosphere fostered by bringing such motivated individuals together, which essentially constitutes the entire management framework of the program.

The Personnel Economics Problem: Selection Without Pay

The main personnel economics problem for the Playa House organization is that it appears to generate strong founder outcomes, but unlike most successful firms and organizations, it does not pay its workers. In a traditional firm, workers' pay helps ensure a successful work environment. It attracts people to the job, recruits people willing to accept it, motivates workers after they are hired, and retains a productive workforce. Playa House does not pay its members, so it may lack many of the traditional structures. Residents at Playa House do not gain any salary benefit from the organization. However, the program still receives a large application pool, is highly selective, and creates output success similar to other startups. This makes Playa House an interesting research topic for examining the types of compensation used to substitute for monetary value.

The first research topic is an analysis of the selectivity of Playa House. According to Leon, the program specifically chooses people who are "obsessed" with an industry or problem area. All members are expected to adopt a long-term mindset focused on their interests rather than a short-term goal of making money quickly. He emphasized that strong applicants are those who have a precise interest in mind and have conducted research or taken action to pursue it. This explains how the admission process prioritizes future potential and intrinsic motivation instead of focusing on current abilities. Since many of the applicants are still in their early stages and lack measurable traction, Leon compares the process to venture capital investing by explaining that it requires "focusing on understanding the logic behind the applicant's project and analyzing the application's potential, rather than its current results." This information problem mirrors findings that workers sort inefficiently between startups precisely because firms provide few credible quality signals, and that supplying even coarse expert assessments measurably shifts application behavior (Bryan et al., 2022).

This creates a selection problem, since the typical characteristics that increase someone's likelihood of admission also make them more likely to succeed without the Playa House. If a resident is already motivated, capable, persistent, and

surrounded by startup opportunities in Santa Barbara, they typically would not need the Playa House's help. Additionally, if they were to join the Playa House, there is no definite reason their future success is because of the house. The organization may seem more effective than it actually is because it is already recruiting strong candidates who are likely to build successful companies. This is important because the application process is already very difficult, as indicated by the extremely low acceptance rate (7/100 and 5/200 from cycles 1 and 2, respectively). Given the demanding admissions requirements, the results of the residents may reflect the selection of the most suitable applicants rather than the organization's direct effect.

The second part of the problem emphasizes motivation without any financial incentive. Once residents are admitted to Playa House, they have no performance incentives, managerial oversight, milestones, or any structured work. Residents are not paid for revenue, produce launches, hours worked, or funding. Instead, motivation is mainly from living in a house full of people with similar interests, which can be an effective way to motivate residents. Leon described the main value of the Playa House as creating a community and explained how placing talented people in proximity could generate positive feedback loops. Residents are surrounded by founders every day, which can increase effort in their startups, speed up learning, and even help when dealing with failure. This suggests that Playa House functions less like a typical corporate environment and more like a healthy community with similar interests, goals, and mindsets.

This leads us to the main question: are the Playa House founders successful because of the selective admission process, or does being a resident change their behavior after they have been selected from proximity? This question matters because the program plans to expand further. The website frames Playa House as a founder house for UCSB students, where Leon discusses the organization's long-term vision to include multiple houses focused on areas such as hardware, cyber, drones, and research. If the program's success comes from selection, then the expansion of Playa House depends on continuing to have good candidates to select from. However, if success is due to interactions within the environment, the organization faces issues like maintaining a community that upholds its current beliefs. The problem is also connected to personnel economics notions about hiring and incentives. Playa House's admissions team must "hire" members as "employees" to create a manager-employee relationship. Incentives are important because the organization must motivate its residents without pay. Peer effects matter because success comes from proximity; if residents work harder, the surrounding people will do the same. This sheds light on how Playa House is an example of how non-monetary jobs can substitute for pay. Since no paycheck is offered, status, community, information, and mentorship serve as the company's benefits.

One research question we can explore is the extent to which Playa House improves founder outcomes due to selection or to the creation of a tight-knit founder community. In addition, we can address whether non-monetary incentives are enough to maintain residents' work ethic and ability, even without financial compensation. These questions focus on Playa House's future strategy depending on the answer. If the main focus is selection, the organization should focus on improving its application process. If it were creating a community, it should focus on the small interactions within the house. Most likely, both forces have an impact, but the empirical strategy is to distinguish them as much as possible.

Proposed Data and Measurement Approach

To analyze data and determine whether selection or proximity leads to greater value within Playa House, we propose measuring this using a dataset comparing outcomes for those who were rejected versus those accepted, as well as measuring outcomes before and after acceptance for the accepted residents. Accepted founders would make up the treatment group, and non-accepted applicants would make up the control group.

The control group would also not include every rejected applicant, but rather only those who were close to making the accepted cohort. This is to reduce selection bias, as there's obviously a significant amount of variation in output between those who were rejected and those who were accepted, as the pool of rejected applicants has only a few people who are comparable to those accepted. Furthermore, given that the sample size is roughly 14 to 40 times larger for the control group than for the treatment (93 and 195 rejected applicants for cycles 1 and 2, respectively), the top 5-10 applicants in the control group are likely to be significantly more similar to those in the treatment vs. the bottom 50-100. To measure this sort of "ranking," we can ask Leon about each rejected applicant and which ones he felt were closest to making it in each application cycle, and then compare. As mentioned in the interview, one applicant, Victor, had traits that Leon quickly recognized after his application in the first cycle, causing him to bring Victor onto the cohort for the second cycle. Cases like Victor can be valuable as they provide examples of applicants who were initially rejected but later got accepted, making them useful for comparing those who were just nearly accepted.

Success can be measured through a variety of different variables that can be collected for both applicants who were accepted and very close to being accepted. These measures would include revenue generated, funding raised, number of customers, MVP (minimum viable product) development linked to other KPIs (key performance indicators), placements, and results from competitions (e.g., hackathons), etc., for both treatment and control groups. Gathering this quantitative data would make it possible to compare numbers from both groups and also before & after applying, resembling personnel economics studies that analyze worker characteristics and selection decisions that are then compared to later outcomes (Hoffman et al., 2018). This

would thus help identify whether Playa House's selection and admissions process is able to identify founders with high potential, as evidenced by stronger outcomes among accepted applicants than comparable non-accepted applicants. This data could be obtained by surveying members of each group, as the sample size of each group is relatively small, and we can inquire with Leon to access application & admissions records maintained by him and Playa House. We can also conduct online research for any information that is available online for these members' projects.

However, Playa House's measurement of success would go deeper than just analyzing numbers, as it's more subjective and specific to what founders want to see for themselves. According to Leon, success within the house is found if someone achieved the goal they specifically set for themselves regarding their project, not just raising money. Because each applicant likely has noticeably different goals and also joined the application cycle at different stages in their development, the data would have to also include individual-specific outcomes to paint the most accurate picture. Like for these original measures, we can also survey each member from both groups and first ask them about the key milestone they wanted to achieve. This could range anywhere from acquiring their first customer to reaching 100 customers per month, getting accepted into a program or winning 1st place, landing a research position, etc. Then, data can be observed for whether or not each individual met their specific goal, and would be factored into the success measurements used in the grand empirical strategy. This individual-specific variable may also pose an advantage in this research compared to standard measures for larger residencies and startups, as those rely on heavy numerical data but thus pushes this qualitative factor of whether or not applicants achieved their goal to the side, whereas here Playa House can still spotlight this question in its currently developing stages. To analyze proximity effects, we would also collect information regarding interactions among founders within Playa House, putting the "accepted vs. rejected" comparison to the side. These variables can include frequency of collaboration, amount of time spent working alongside each other (non-collaborative), participation in house activities, and project discussions (to measure how often ideas are exchanged and bounced off each other), following personnel economics studies that study how communication, knowledge sharing, and interactions among workers affect worker productivity (Sandvik et al., 2020). As Leon stated, the community has been the key driver of value creation within Playa House. Using these measures in our grand dataset would allow us to determine if and to what extent greater interaction is linked to positive outcomes for founders.

Empirical Strategy and Identification

Running through the data, our proposed empirical strategy and identification would involve three different complementary comparisons, each isolating the benefit of selection, the effect of proximity, and the program's overall causal influence as it scales. Since Playa House is not a randomized experiment, identification is based on naturally occurring fluctuations in the quantity of people admitted, the extent to which rejected candidates remained attached to the setting, and the level of interaction among the residents who were accepted. In order to determine the program's benefit, the core specification compares the accepted founders with the applicants who were determined to be on the verge of admission in our data section. We assess the influence on both since the data section describes two types of outcomes: a subjective goal-attainment measure and hard quantitative measurements. The formula of the quantitative model is:

$$Y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{Accepted}_i) + \beta_2(X_i) + \varepsilon_i$$

Y_i represents the standardized founder outcome (funding raised, revenue, customers, MVP/KPI progress, or competition placement). X_i is a vector of pre-selection controls that include technical ability, past experience, if they arrived with a functioning product, field, and prior startup experience. Accepted_i represents 1 if applicant i was admitted, and ε_i is the error term. The coefficient of interest, or β_1 , is the projected impact of admission while maintaining a constant level of visible applicant quality. Moreover, this regression examines only the borderline pool, not the full set of 93 and 195 rejections, indicating that the vast majority of candidates who were never near acceptance do not influence β_1 . In order to determine the worth of a selection choice, personnel-economics research ties pre-hire candidate attributes to later realized results (Hoffman et al., 2018). We estimate a parallel model with a binary goal-attainment outcome since Leon also defines success subjectively, if a founder attained the particular milestone they set for themselves:

$$\text{GoalMet}_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{Accepted}_i) + \beta_2(X_i) + \varepsilon_i$$

Utilizing a logit specification or linear probability, GoalMet_i represents 1 if the founder achieved their self-reported goal. Implementing both models, we can determine whether admission affects hard financial metrics, self-defined success, or both. This is essential since a resident who quietly achieves their own goal can appear to be a failure based just on money. A second approach focuses specifically on proximity. We exploit variations in the interaction metrics, which include collaboration frequency, feedback given and received, and co-working, to estimate:

$$Y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{Interaction_Intensity}_i) + \beta_2(X_i) + \varepsilon_i$$

A positive β_1 indicates that the dense peer network provides benefits beyond selection. In addition, we are cautious since the founder determines the level of contact, resulting in highly motivated residents having the opportunity to interact more and achieve more success in any residence. This causes β_1 to be rather suggestive than strictly causal, prompting it to be combined with the admission comparison rather than isolated. Comparing "high-exposure" to "low-exposure" rejections treats closeness

as a continuous treatment rather than an on/off switch because some rejected candidates continue to attend Founder Dinners and collaborate with residents.

The third empirical strategy leverages the program's planned expansion as more of a quasi-natural experiment, utilizing the difference-in-differences framework. As Playa House scales its operations across multiple locations, shifts occur concurrently in both applicant quality and peer density. By comparing subsequent cohorts within the original house to residents of newly constructed locations, we can disentangle these mechanisms that shape each location. For example, if residents' outcomes decline in newly constructed, less-networked houses while admission criteria remain constant, this would support the proximity effect. In contrast, if diminished resident outcomes are driven by less strenuous admission requirements, the selection mechanism will be supported. Although this design requires data from future cohorts and houses, it offers the most robust source of variation available for this analysis.

One implication we would also like to address is selection bias, which remains the underlying threat to β_1 . The concern is due to the fact that the same traits that earn admission into Playa House, such as persistence, prior exposure, and grit, also predict success regardless of the program. Not addressing these factors can lead to the acceptance coefficient also capturing the quality of people Playa House sorts rather than its true causal contribution. We can address this in three ways. First, limiting the control group to borderline rejects reduces the ability gap between the treatment and control groups, making the program, rather than innate skill, more likely to account for the remaining difference in results. Second, the observable qualities of applicants that Leon assesses at admission are captured by the pre-selection control vector X_1 . Third, within-applicant variation provides the greatest influence when it occurs. Victor, who was denied in the first cycle and accepted in the second, can theoretically be perceived on both sides of the threshold, enabling a before-and-after comparison that determines his core capability.

Furthermore, the residual bias is not one-sided, but rather ambiguous. Selection on unobserved drive increases β_1 , therefore inflating the program's impact. However, partial treatment in the control group has the opposite effect, narrowing the difference between the treatment and control groups. This leads to β_1 becoming biased toward zero and understating the actual effect, since borderline-significant results still absorb some of the environment through co-working and Founder Dinners. We are clear that any estimated β_1 should be understood as a bounded approximation of the program's effect rather than a clean causal estimate. While no single strategy completely removes these confounders, when combined, they strengthen the relationship between admission and outcomes.

Implications and Recommendations for Playa House

The main implication of this study is that Playa House should really divide its model into 3 different parts: 1) what does the environment do for selected founders, 2) why do these founders continue working hard despite any pay, and 3) who is selected and why. Currently, Playa House combines all three successfully since it can attract a large number of applicants, accept a small number of residents, create a community for the residents, and relies on non-monetary motivation instead of salary or equity. However, since all of these factors operate simultaneously, it is difficult to determine whether founder success stems from the quality of the community's people, the influence of living among other founders, or the motivational environment. If the model works purely because of the selection process, then growth depends on maintaining a strong application pool. If it works because of the non-monetary motivation, then expansion must ensure that the house does not become too formal like a company, where employees (founders) would have to be paid since it is a job-like situation.

Next, we recommend that Playa House should track founder outcomes and success in a way that is measurable. Since residents work on so many different types of startups and projects, success cannot be measured by a single metric. One founder's success may be raising enough money for a project, and another may mean signing a contract. Although it may be difficult, Playa House should find a way to show how each resident is doing compared to other residents. The organization should track revenue, project launches, number of customers, and any major shifts in companies. These outcomes can show Playa House the progress along its founders and better understand which models tend to be more successful and valuable.

Our third recommendation is that Playa House should analyze the proximity effects on founders. Leon described the community as physically very close, and this was one of the most important values of the household. Because this is so important to the organization, a way to collect data on interactions should be implemented; for example, a monthly survey could ask residents how their housemates helped them that month, who gave the best feedback, or even how people helped them when they felt lost. This can show Playa House whether founders' communication can impact their companies' success. If the more social and professional residents show greater progress, it will show that proximity is not just a good feature of the program; it will also be evident that it has an impact on founder productivity.

We also recommend that Playa House continue not to pay their founders. A significant part of the organization is not having any pay involved, and this shows that motivation purely comes from non-monetary sources like ambition, social comparison, peer accountability, and access to resources. Playa House should not introduce any monitoring system or performance requirements, as this would shift the organization toward a more job-like environment. Instead, the program should just ensure structure by setting practices and events like monthly goals, peer accountability groups, dinners for the founders, and informal progress updates. This would ensure autonomy while creating a friendly environment.

Our fifth and final recommendation is that Playa House should expand and treat each new house as an experiment. The program may grow too quickly, which may cause admissions standards to decline. Also, if the communities are more spread out, the individual founders may be less connected, and the community may have an impact because of that. Therefore, Playa House should not assume that adding a lot of houses is the best idea. Each new house should incorporate the same selection quality and interaction intensity. A measurement of strength between old and new residents should be required, along with the number of interactions.

An expansion strategy that would preserve the values of the current household is to build houses and share communities among one another. For example, Playa House could have houses with special expertise, like a hardware house, software house, research house, and cyber house. It would be a small group of residents that can interact with one another daily. Then, to incorporate the four houses together, larger events like weekly dinners, investor sessions, and an event for houses to work together could be the bridge between the houses. This allows Playa House to benefit from scaling while maintaining the small-community structure that boosts effort and motivation.

Overall, Playa House should view selection and proximity differently but ensure both are preserved, in order to see the variables that change and their impact on their results. Selection determines who is allowed into the program, while proximity shapes the community once they are accepted. The unpaid nature of the program makes the program unique because residents are not motivated by money, but are motivated by the people surrounding them. The idea of being part of a founder community and the pressure of the ambitious students around them would drive ambitious people to work harder for the spot. The goal should not be to make the program more formal, but to collect information to see the main reason why their students are so successful.

Limitations & Open Questions

The central limitation of this study is separating the program's causal effect from the ability of people it admits. For example, imagine a scenario in which the data indicated that accepted applicants typically secured around \$150,000 in funding over a year, while rejected applicants raised barely any funds; it is easy to attribute the difference to the program. However, consider the individual who successfully completed a \$250,000 pre-seed fundraiser: if that individual already had a functional product and some fundraising experience, the program's influence might be minimal. Since Playa House accepts only about one in forty applicants and focuses on characteristics that predict success, the sharp difference can exaggerate its true influence. A more balanced approach would be to just compare the cases where the program manager had mixed feelings: for instance, two applicants who both showed up with a working prototype and a hackathon win, where one got in, and one got rejected. Since these applicants are similar in technical ability, any difference in how they perform in the post-selection process is much more likely to reflect program impact rather than who they were in the pre-selection process. One major factor that can skew this examination is how close the rejected applicants stay to the Playa House environment. Leon stated that rejected applicants attend Founder Dinner events, hang out with accepted applicants, and sometimes co-work alongside them. This means that they still get a partial experience of the environment the study is trying to measure, possibly minimizing the program's true effect.

An important open question focuses on the program's own plans. Suppose Playa House grows from one house of ten to five houses of ten, and average funding per founder decreases from \$120,000 to \$40,000. Will the results still hold up? What are some reasons that could possibly explain this slip: growth diluting the peer proximity that fosters success or the program being forced to admit weaker applicants in the name of "expansion"? Since expansion can shift both density and applicant quality, the program can be treated as a natural experiment. This involves comparing the subsequent cohorts of the original program with the new programs using a difference-in-differences approach to distinguish selection from proximity. For an organization that relies entirely on this balance, it is important that this question is addressed as the program aims to grow.

Conclusion

To conclude, the purpose of this paper was to examine an issue in personnel economics within the context of Playa House, a startup residency for young founders in the Santa Barbara area. We focused on answering the question, "How much does the success of a founder depend on the selection of high-ability candidates or the influence of a close-knit, unpaid community, and what motivates founders to work hard without financial benefit?" Drawing from a conversation with the program manager Leon Khoshnevis, the research suggested an outline for studying these questions empirically. It describes how Playa House could explain what constitutes founder success, evaluate each resident's interactions with the peer community, and compare successful founders with those who were nearly admitted, thereby distinguishing the residency's true impact from the capabilities of those selected.

The paper provides suggestions that are based on specific principles of personnel economics: aligning strategies with whichever factor turns out to be stronger, refining the selection process if it is the choice that influences outcomes or maintaining a dense cohort if it is the peer effect that matters, and implementing straightforward evaluation techniques such as a standardized application guideline, an initial survey for new applicants, and tracking outcomes for both accepted and declined candidates. Given the program's lack of funding for salaries and limited formal organization, these suggestions are intentionally low-cost and non-hierarchical.

While the research is constrained by a small sample size (12 founders) and also the challenge of separating selection bias and causal relationships, it presents a practical approach to utilizing personnel economics in a direct environment. Our goal was to break down a highly motivating environment and demonstrate that core concepts like selection, incentive, and peer-impact are relevant in an unpaid program, highlighting them. We would like to thank Leon Khoshnevis for his willingness to share insights with us, helping to transform the core principles of Playa House into a subject for extensive study, and possibly further experimentation.

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